

RIVALROUS MASCULINITIES

*New Directions in
Medieval Gender Studies*

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CHAPTER FIVE

The Knight versus the Courtier

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Widening opportunities for courtiers in France from the end of the Hundred Years' War through the middle of the sixteenth century meant that increasing numbers of noblemen chose this profession and its submissive masculinity over that of the independent, violent masculinity of the knight. The supposed fusion of military usefulness with that of a clerk's legal education made the courtier's career more palatable to some in the nobility because it permitted a customary link to privilege through warfare, even if it was only for show, while increasing their usefulness to a progressively bureaucratic monarchy. For the first time since its inception, the traditional image of the knight faced a rival masculinity that could topple it from its hegemony due to the changing needs of the state.

Yet the knight would not so easily yield prominence of place to a gender model that was traditionally considered effeminate by the populace.¹ The long sixteenth century was in many ways a "gender crucible" in which certain aspects of both masculinities were fused into a new form, but it was the knight who ultimately emerged victorious.² While the courtier embraced a legal education and affectation (widely considered feminine traits), knights professionalized their role in war and clung tenaciously to independence and violence as a measure of their masculinity. Increasingly restricted access to monarchically approved violent display may have breathed life into the private dueling craze at the end of the sixteenth century. Regardless, this willing reconstruction occurred during a period of monarchical instability as the king himself struggled between embracing the masculinity of the courtier over that of the knight. The king's crisis helped preserve the knight's gender model, with its concomitant rights to violence and independence, as the hegemonic masculinity into the seventeenth century.

NOBLE MASCULINITY AT ODDS

Nothing encapsulates the supposed ascendancy of the courtier over the knight in the sixteenth century more than the infamous duel between François de Vivonne, seigneur de La Châtaigneraye, and Guy Chabot, baron de Jarnac, in 1547.³ Châtaigneraye was noted as one of the best fighters of his day and was a companion of the dauphin, Henry. Jarnac, in contrast, was a bookish courtier whose sister-in-law was Anne Jeanne de Pisseleu, duchesse d'Etampes and young mistress of Henry's father, King Francis I. Always at odds with the duchesse, Henry asked Jarnac how he had acquired such rich clothes, and Jarnac responded that they were a gift from his stepmother. Henry repeated this to others at court but twisted the words so that the implication was that Jarnac admitted not only to being funded by a woman rather than his own merits but also to being in an incestuous relationship with her. Henry claimed that the source of the rumor was actually Châtaigneraye, who said he had heard it from the lips of Jarnac himself. When Jarnac called him a liar Châtaigneraye pressed for the right to

settle the matter in a judicial duel. For over a year King Francis would not hear of it, but once Francis died the issue came to the forefront of court again since it related to the honor of the new king. Henry II granted the duel a mere three weeks after ascending to the throne and a full two weeks before he was actually crowned.⁴

Châtaigneraye and Jarnac were vastly different: Châtaigneraye was “a man very adroit with arms, of invincible courage, and who had made a thousand proofs and a thousand hazards of his valor; and the other was not, whose profession was more the courtier and fop with his curious clothes, rather than that of arms and of the warrior.”⁵ In preparation for the duel, Jarnac pursued an education with an Italian fencing master, while Châtaigneraye, who “feared his enemy no more than a lion the dog,” lived it up with his friends, expecting little contest from the bookish courtier (Carloix I.II.XII). To the bewilderment of himself and everyone else, Jarnac won by slicing the tendons of Châtaigneraye’s calf in a maneuver now called the Coup de Jarnac. Amazed that his knight had been bested, Henry, who was presiding over the duel, did not throw the baton to end the fight, even though Jarnac pleaded with him to do so. The knight staggered back to his feet for another attempt, only to have the maneuver performed again on his other leg. Still Henry waited since his honor was at stake as well. Although he would eventually end the fight, his knight bled to death on the field of combat and the courtier emerged unscathed and victorious. Five days after the duel Henry passed an edict against dueling and never granted the field of combat again.⁶

Yet the courtier as violent victor over the knight from this point forward does not hold up as a model. Courtiers had never been nor would they be soldiers, no matter how much Baldassare Castiglione might claim them to be in his famous work, *The Book of the Courtier*. Throughout the medieval world courtiers were routinely painted as court parasites and a symbol of the corruption inherent in court life.⁷ In the fourteenth century poets like Eustache Deschamps (d. 1406) criticized the lifestyle, clothing, and conduct of courtiers, a lament that became more common as courtiers adopted extravagant Italian costuming and mannerisms in the late fifteenth century.⁸ Such vitriol was especially true when it came from soldiers, as “antagonism between the soldier and courtier was a prominent feature of the anti-court tradition.”⁹ While poets such as Deschamps lampooned the outward appearance of the courtier, soldiers targeted the profession’s lack of independence as a source of derision and scorn. Jean de Bueil, a lifelong soldier in the service of France, wrote his semiautobiographical work, *Le Jouvençal* (ca. 1466), as a manual for young gentlemen. While he laments the traditional corruptive influences of court, such as laziness and greed, he also suggests that ultimately his free will and honesty were in jeopardy because of the submissiveness required when one held an office at the will and pleasure of another.¹⁰ As Michel de Montaigne would say almost a century later, “A courtier can have neither the right nor the will to speak and think otherwise than favorably of a master. . . . This favor and advantage corrupts his freedom.”¹¹ Such a lack of independence made the courtier less of a man in the eyes of the nobility.

Thus a courtier’s submissiveness placed him closer to the clerk than the knight.¹² The nobility of France still believed that a formal education was harmful to a career in arms and resulted in a “devirilization” of their estate.¹³ For instance, in 1517 the humanist Richard Pace related that an unnamed noble had said to him that learned men were all beggars, and further: “It becomes the sons of gentlemen to blow the horn nicely, to hunt skillfully, and elegantly to carry and train a hawk. The study of letters was for rustics[;] . . . rather my son should hang.”¹⁴ Courtiers were not “old soldiers” diverted into a different type of service to the crown or a direct descendant of the knight.¹⁵ Indeed, as Cecil H. Clough has shown, the majority of real-life individuals depicted in Castiglione’s *Courtier* had either little or no military experience, and nearly all of them ended up pursuing advanced careers in the church.¹⁶ Until Castiglione, martial activities had never been part of the courtier’s job description.¹⁷ François Billacois has noted that social conviction dictated that the *noblesse de robe* was not permitted to wear a sword or participate in dueling, which were the masculine hallmarks of the *noblesse d’épée*.¹⁸

Yet despite the lack of real connection to violence as a profession, or perhaps because of it, C. A. J. Armstrong has stated that by the mid-fifteenth century academically trained men from a clerical background were becoming the most successful court climbers.¹⁹ Access to the favors of the king was increasingly based on legal expertise rather than feudal relationships, and noble sons who sought out advantageous offices might be prevented from obtaining them if they did not have the requisite law degree.²⁰ Louis XII and Francis I sold dozens of newly created offices to men who had never held office before.²¹ The number of household officials grew from 318 in 1490 to 540 in 1523. Furthermore, this was accompanied by a staggering increase in wages.²²

Castiglione's recasting of the courtier and the increasing sale of offices to such "new" men indicate that this profession, and more important the submissive masculinity tied to it, was becoming more prominent during the sixteenth century. As Kathleen Wilson-Chevalier has claimed, the monarchy was "laboring to transmute the traditional *noblesse* (potentially turbulent lords) into educated courtiers (faithful allies)."²³ This may have been one of the reasons that King Francis I had himself portrayed as half man, half woman in a portrait, invoking Mars by wearing armor and a sword and sporting the dress of Minerva, goddess of wisdom. If their king could be learned and wise, yet still virile and courageous, then so too could the nobility.

Francis supported humanist academics at court by creating a number of professorships for the study of Greek and Hebrew.²⁴ These humanists did not miss the opportunity to express their feelings on traditional noble masculinity. Dominic Baker-Smith has argued that the English invasion of France in 1513 awakened the humanist critique of violence and traditional nobility. Academics were surprised that chivalry could still have such a tremendous effect on international politics, and it was not until this time that humanists found their full voice against the noble warrior.²⁵ For instance, Desiderius Erasmus, one of the most vocal critics of knights, compared the type of men who participated in war to base thieves, arsonists, pirates, and robbers, concluding, "If you want to see clearly what a ruffianly exercise war is, just look at the men who carry it on."²⁶ According to Erasmus, men who were produced by and carried out such violence were the worst type of men, as they "grow fat on the miseries of the people."²⁷ At the very same time that the monarchy was understanding the benefits of employing those with a legal education, the usefulness and worth of the knight was publicly besieged by the educated elite.

What could a knight do in the face of such a critique? Much of his identity and masculinity was tied directly to the application of violence, and violence was the very thing that monarchies were limiting access to and that critics disdained. The *compagnies d'ordonnance*, created as a standing army by Charles VII in 1445, combined heavy cavalry, mounted archers, and infantry into twenty companies of six hundred men each. Logistically, these forces were still centered on mounted noblemen, but the companies drew from all levels of society. While the *compagnies* did not replace the feudal levy altogether, they did provide a transitional force into modern, infantry-based warfare.²⁸ However, Davis Bitton has demonstrated that when the people of the sixteenth century lamented the decline of the feudal nobility, they pointed to three interrelated trends born from these changes: the infrequent use of feudal levies (the *ban et arrière-ban*), the increased deployment of infantry instead of cavalry, and a lack of class boundaries in military units.²⁹

More specifically, changes in military tactics and the use of gunpowder weapons forced soldiers from horseback; now on foot, they were expected to fight like cogs in a machine, thrusting them into anonymity.³⁰ Such anonymity had an impact on noble masculinity in two important ways. First, in order to establish their masculinity, nobles needed their deeds to be deemed worthy and honorable by other honorable men.³¹ As noted by Blaise de Monluc, a marshal of France in the late sixteenth century, leaders ought to praise deserving men in public because compliments were better than any monetary reward, specifically because of the power of a reputation.³² In one instance, he takes credit for having convinced his superiors to confront Charles V during the 1544 invasion of France. Unfortunately for him, another man had already rushed to the king and shared the good news, prompting Monluc to angrily proclaim that honorable men should not "cloth themselves with the spoils of another man's honor, nor conceal the bravery of any from the greatest to the least" (Monluc, bk. II). Monluc went on to say that there was never anything so despicable than to risk your life for a cause only to have your name concealed from the master (even though generals did it all the time) (Monluc, bk. II). Anonymity meant that the knight could not be deemed honorably masculine and that he was made invisible to other potential rewards.

Second, the inclusion of the peasantry as a vital component of war alongside the nobility helped spoil the notion that a single order of society earned its privileges by bearing arms for the sake of all others.³³ Nobles and peasants alike stood together, making it hard to differentiate between the value of the two groups to the crown. The pillar of chivalry himself, Pierre Terrail, seigneur de Bayard, was at one point a captain of the foot, and Monluc's entire storied career was based on his preference for infantry command.³⁴ François de Scépeaux, seigneur de Vieilleville and eventual marshal of France, commented in 1552 that a great number of young gentlemen had never been on a horse before and had, therefore, become *gens à pied*, or foot soldiers (Carloix II.IV.XIII). The unintended result was that by the mid-sixteenth century, royal edicts, ordinances, and mandates treated the peasant-dominated infantry with the same level of importance as the nobly manned cavalry.³⁵ From

the monarchy's perspective, why reward a knight with land, titles, and respect when peasants could achieve the same results at less cost? Anonymity made it hard for a knight to establish his masculinity while lessening the value of knights to kings.

A knight's masculinity was not just tied to violence, however. Since knightly masculinity was directly associated with the right and courage to assert his will (by violence if necessary), in order to be respected as a man a knight needed to make sure that he never gave the perception of uncontested submission to another man.³⁶ If a nobleman did not speak his mind about what he felt was right to his king or lord, he was sacrificing his *franchise*, a slippery term that combines the knight's right to speak and act freely with the need to be honest and sincere. *Sprezzatura*, a creation of Castiglione that embodies a studied nonchalance or disguising of one's true desires and feelings, implies a submissiveness and falsehood that galled noble warriors, as suggested by Bueil's and Montaigne's comments noted above.³⁷ The intent behind one's actions mattered to knights. For instance, Castiglione felt that fighting courtiers ought to "strive to be as elegant and handsome . . . to attract the eyes of spectators."³⁸ Knights such as Jean du Bueil wanted to believe that their goal when fighting was "to defend [their own] rights and those of others" (de Bueil I.I.CCXC). Bueil also claimed that nobles who did not fight could not have issued from noble lines and that their mothers must have been whores (de Bueil I.II.XIX). Moreover, Monluc claimed that the life of a courtier did not suit him since he had "ever been too free, and too open hearted to live at court" (Monluc, bk. I). He continually lamented how noble sons who chose to be courtiers or study law had drained France not only of potential soldiers but, more important, of honor as well (Monluc, bk. VI). According to men who fought, the ideal courtier was an opportunist and sought a career as a submissive servant of those with power whereas the ideal knight was honest and sought glory by testing his courage and skill against other worthy opponents.³⁹

As much as soldiers like Monluc might lament that all the law books in France should be burned to remove the courtier as a career option for noble sons, by midcentury the courtier had gained significant ground on the knight (Monluc, bk. VI). Nicolas Le Roux has shown that the people of the second half of the sixteenth century looked to the radical court of Henry II that favored the courtier over the warrior as the beginning of the civil disorders that erupted into the wars of religion.⁴⁰ The reversal of fortunes for the once-dominant knight continued during Charles IX's reign. The lieutenant general of Chanteuil, Vincent de la Loupe, said in 1564 that in order to better serve the people the king was forced to favor the learned over the wellborn warrior.⁴¹ When he was crowned in 1575, Henry III bestowed his prestigious household positions on men of minor noble status who styled themselves as courtiers. By favoring his *mignons* over those who had previous military service to the kingdom of France, Henry III effectively incensed the feudal nobility.⁴²

TOO FAR, TOO FAST

Social change happens very slowly, especially when that change is tied to the foundations of moral behavior in a time of growing crisis across multiple levels of society. While Francis may have wanted his nobility to embrace education as a mark of distinction and usefulness, he was by no means suggesting that they sacrifice their masculinity to do it. By his eighteenth birthday in 1512, Francis was the captain of one hundred lances. Upon his coronation in 1515, he immediately invaded Italy and won back the majority of the territory the French claimed but had lost in previous years.⁴³ As a militant king who fathered numerous legitimate children (three boys and two girls), Francis's masculinity was in little doubt. It is for this reason that he could commission the aforementioned portrait that melded masculine and feminine gods while remaining secure in his masculinity. Cross-dressing and gender bending were relatively common occurrences in the late medieval and early modern worlds.⁴⁴ However, the only time that men cross-dressing as women was tolerated was when their masculinity was least in doubt, such as during a tournament.⁴⁵ Noblemen could and did engage in gender bending but only from a position of relative safety such as when the perception of military action would make the idea of female participation socially absurd.

Much like his father, Henry II was also secure in his masculinity, having earned a reputation as one of the best kings for soldiers that ever reigned from Monluc, who himself was likened to one who only cared about fighting (Monluc, bk. IV; Monluc, bk. II). Henry II spent years fighting against the Spanish and was able to regain territories in Italy, although with mixed results. Nonetheless, Henry II also amply provided for posterity,

having fathered even more legitimate children than his father (five boys and three girls). Therefore, when he opened up his masculinity to question he did so from a position of relative safety. As an obvious nod to his mistress, Diane de Poitiers, he had the goddess Diana prominently displayed in the foreground of works produced under his patronage. While this image suggested submission to a woman, it also was effective in exalting Henry's potency.⁴⁶

Henry III, however, was nowhere near as secure in his masculinity as his father and grandfather. By cross-dressing at major festivals, Henry III "was trying to express his majesty and leadership of the court within a recent royal tradition of gender ambiguity and sexual representation."⁴⁷ As mentioned above, however, Francis's and Henry II's masculinity were never in doubt. They had both widely participated in war, fathered legitimate heirs, and associated with high-ranking nobles, even if they had increasingly found use for courtiers. Henry III's military reputation was never firmly established enough to offset his manipulation of gender. By the time he rose to the throne in 1576 he had inherited an army that was financially and emotionally exhausted, which "paralyzed the crown's ability to exert effective military force against its disobedient subjects."⁴⁸ Beyond military failures, a multitude of issues arose that derailed his policy of gender ambiguity and made his sexuality an issue for uncontrolled criticism. For instance, prior to becoming the king, Henry was known for his heterosexual escapades, but this was interpreted as a sign of feminine weakness because he was unable to control his lust instead of pursuing more masculine pursuits such as war.⁴⁹ His inability to control his brother (Hercules Francis), his controversial marriage to Louise of Lorraine, and his failure to produce an heir all contributed further to a growing uncertainty about the king's masculinity, but none more than his supposed dalliances with courtiers.

Once Henry became Henry III, he filled his prestigious household positions with men from obscure families of the secondary nobility rather than from the most noteworthy families in France.⁵⁰ In addition, the king's new advisers were not only courtiers, but "aggressively 'other,' even to the point of embracing change and innovation in order to accentuate their otherness," and people considered them dangerous because of it.⁵¹ The danger to society was twofold. Their blatant "courtier-ness" set them apart from the traditional image of masculine monarchical stability: the knight. In a time of such great conflict, how could the French be expected to stomach the abandonment of the image of the king as a warrior whose position in society was predicated on being a defender of the people, especially when their new king had little to no military reputation to begin with? In addition, advisers to the king needed to be of relatively equal social position so that they could exercise their *franchise* to be honest and truthful with him should he decide to pursue some folly, trusting that they did not need his patronage to survive. Men of lesser status might fear to speak up against the king's plans while also raising the question as to why they were chosen for the position over more powerful men. For instance, if men of the lesser nobility were chosen over their "natural betters" in Elizabethan England waves of suspicion arose throughout society, leading to charges of sodomy.⁵² How else would they have been able to rise to such heights if not for having some other, hidden influence?

The aggressive otherness of Henry III's courtiers reignited fears of effeminacy and led to a direct association with sodomy at court, much to the benefit of the knight. As the courtier rose in prominence, from 1500 to the death of Henry II in 1559, attacks levied at courtiers were primarily inspired by reactions to Castiglione and the adoption of social politeness.⁵³ While charges of sodomy could indicate political, social, or religious transgressions during this time, it is unusual that such accusations are largely absent from society in the early sixteenth century.⁵⁴ For instance, Stuart Carroll has shown that there were very few references to buggery as a precursor to duels and that those that exist appear fairly late, with the earliest in 1565.⁵⁵ Likewise, Goran Stanivukovic has shown that in the heroic culture and heroic literature of early modern Europe there was nothing erotic about depictions of passionate male friendship in and of itself.⁵⁶ In the court of Henry III, however, accusations of homosexuality among members of court, up to and including the king himself, ran rampant.⁵⁷ Thus accusations of sodomy in the last third of the sixteenth century were relatively new.

The two works most frequently cited for homosexual references are Pierre de L'Estoile's *Mémoires-Journaux* and *L'Isle de hermaphrodites*, attributed to one Arthur Thomas. L'Estoile was born into a family of illustrious Parisian lawyers, and his journal, which runs from 1574 up to his death in 1611, is the earliest example of personal and popular writing about homosexual practices in the postclassical West.⁵⁸ His journal provides a link to the second work by connecting the perceived immorality of the real French court to the fictional island.⁵⁹ *Les hermaphrodites*, on the other hand, was published in 1605 and was one of a "large

quantity of anonymous doggerel” that satirized the court of Henry III, though it never mentioned the king by name.⁶⁰ By “hermaphrodites,” the reader was to understand “adult male sodomite,” though the work peddled a vague stereotype that has been read as more of a critique on vanity and dandyism than an actual reflection of reality.⁶¹ Regardless, literary and political tracts of French Renaissance writing depicted sodomy as a specifically aristocratic vice imported from Italy, the land of the courtier, especially during Henry III’s reign.⁶² As an *aristocratic* vice, such accusations would have affected the knight as well.

Had Henry III firmly established his masculinity by participating in war and undertaking honorable deeds, like his father and grandfather, he may have been able to weather the storm of criticism regarding his advisers. When their low status is considered with Henry III’s predilection for sex, regardless of the sex of his partner, his court became very suspect indeed. The result was a public backlash against the “increase in the ranks of courtiers, accompanied by a decrease in their social usefulness” during a time of military crisis.⁶³ Essentially, the social inequalities and perceived gross misconduct occurring in court between noble friends in the last third of the century made people question the very masculinity of all the nobles attending the king as well as their worth to society. In the eyes of the populace, noblemen ought to be fighting to bring the religious wars to an end instead of attending to carnal pursuits at court. These men wallowed in excess, were the cause of all of society’s ills, and wanted to trample underfoot “all ancient institutions.”⁶⁴ By wholly embracing the masculinity of the courtier during this time of crisis, the king opened himself up to critics who used hermaphroditism as a metaphor to explain the current social, political, and religious calamities, which in turn gave the masculinity of the knight an opportunity to regain its footing.

THE EMERGENCE OF FRANCIS’S VISION

If it was his time at court that feminized him and his poor job of advising the king that made him useless, then the curative for both of these issues was to put the noble back in the battlefield, regardless of the fact that many members of the nobility had never left it. In times of relative chaos, it is a natural human response to conjure up images from the past as a model for stability and order. In this case, the traditional image of the knight was used as a curative for the current political fractures and for marking out clearer gender categories that had been muddled by the courtier. Propagandists of the time utilized such a dichotomy by promoting the war hero masculinity of the men of the House of Guise over the ambiguities of royal hermaphroditism.⁶⁵ For instance, in artwork Henry III was portrayed as a harpy, in direct comparison to the conventional image of a warrior used for Guise men.⁶⁶

The renewed interest in the knight was troubled by his lack of education, insistence on free will, and use of violence, all of which had in part been responsible for his demise. In order to alleviate some of this concern, knights sought to control the education that they felt was best for their positions in the military. While humanists may have thought that “the well-born were ignorant, . . . indifferent to learning, and . . . preferred to stay that way,” the reality was somewhat different.⁶⁷ As J. H. Hexter has noted, the purpose of noble education was to produce a man who was “lowly and serviceable, gentle and worthy, loving chivalry, truth, and honor, freedom and courtesy.”⁶⁸ *This did not mean that noblemen did not have an education in letters.* Most noble sons were simply taught by the officers of whatever household they were being raised in at the time rather than university-trained academics.⁶⁹ Indeed, Kathleen Wilson-Chevalier has shown that as early as the 1530s some noblemen were investing heavily in education for their martially destined sons, claiming that men like Guillaume Du Bellay were an example of “a new race of gentlemen: eloquent warriors whose power and intellect had been harnessed to the public (monarchical) good.”⁷⁰ Such men all subscribed to the ideal of the learned soldier, “to whom the pen was almost as manageable as the sword.”⁷¹ Indeed, Yuval Harari’s delightful study on the memoirs of noble soldiers was made possible by the dramatic increase in written works produced by such men.⁷²

That the knight had actually been receiving an education is not new, but what the knight needed now was to make his education seem more professionally oriented and therefore of more use to the crown. D. J. B. Trim has argued that they were able to do this because of the widely held belief that leadership in war was the specific preserve of the aristocracy.⁷³ For instance, Raymond de Beccarie de Pavie (d. 1574), baron of Fourquevaux, fought intermittently for three decades for France and during this time wrote his thoughts on how the military

ought to be organized in order to prevent and reform the decay he saw in military affairs. Fourquevaux listed the three qualities of a good lieutenant general: he needed to possess a noble lineage, to win the will of soldiers; to be rich, to win hearts by gifts; and to be a man of reputation and renown.⁷⁴ Nobility was one of the most important prerequisites for military officers because the army was still staffed by those personally bound to their superiors in both feudal and patron-client relationships.⁷⁵ Indeed, Monluc proclaimed that it was necessary for the nobility to lead others into dangerous situations since they possessed a stouter heart (Monluc, bk. VII). He also claimed that a good captain with one thousand men could best four thousand not nobly led (Monluc, bk. II). Thus the knight was crafting his reputation as useful to the king again by using the logic that he made the army a larger and more effective fighting force.

If nothing else, men like Guillaume du Bellay and his brother Martin demonstrated that you could teach old dogs new tricks or at least style them to appear new. By midcentury knights had also begun to adopt and place emphasis on certain titles that they hoped lent them more esteem as part of their professionalization. René du Bellay, son-in-law of Martin du Bellay and publisher of Martin's and Guillaume's memoirs in the mid-sixteenth century, called Martin a "clerc d'armes" and said that works like his were not to be left under the bed or in a cabinet but rather put to use by the captains of the day.⁷⁶ Monluc continually used the title "Captain" as an indicator of supreme military knowledge and even called Caesar the best captain rather than an emperor (Monluc, bk. I). He also decreed that his memoirs, much like du Bellay's, was to be used by captains who would put his knowledge to work so that they might acquire honor and renown (Monluc, bk. I). Note here that besides the adoption of a term like "clerk," which would have most assuredly drawn offense in the previous century if applied to a knight, these men used such titles to help sell their transformation into useful and active members of an officer corps.

This does not mean that there were no actual changes in the education of the noble warrior and that the professionalization of the knight was merely smoke and mirrors. Knights sought to turn their expertise in war into a scholarly pursuit. As early as the fifteenth century, knights such as Jean de Bueil were claiming that war was governed by art and science (de Bueil I.I.prologue). While this sentiment does not occur with much regularity during this time, Nordhaus has shown that by the end of the fifteenth century treatises on war demonstrate that the increasing complexity of war necessitated that military science be treated as a legitimate discipline.⁷⁷ Indeed, from 1494 to 1610 over ninety titles were published in the categories of general warfare, artillery and engineering, techniques, and miscellaneous categories such as the laws of war.⁷⁸ Although a formal restructuring of noble education occurred rather late, it would not take full effect until the early seventeenth century. Pierre d'Origny made the first proposal for such reform in 1578.⁷⁹ The renowned horse master Antoine de Pluvinel started a school for the nobility in 1594 that focused on horsemanship, fashionable dress, and dancing, even if their dancing and fencing masters were one and the same.⁸⁰ This suggests that the nobility were responding to their critics by trying to give legitimacy to the education they felt was best suited to their job: warrior and statesmen. That their efforts to reassert their usefulness to the crown and society continued to revolve around war demonstrates how important access to violent recourse was for noble warrior masculinity.

While it is clear how riding could translate directly to the profession of war, dancing and fancy dress do not seem quite as comfortable a fit at first glance. However, Francis's original program of reform was not just about education but also about culture. The gruff battlefield demeanor of the knight needed to be one of the casualties of war with his rival the courtier, and besides, the footwork of dancing could imitate the footwork of fighting maneuvers. Yet the manners and fashions of the courtier that had become popular before Henry III's *mignons* pushed the envelope too far were not lost completely on the knight, even if Norbert Elias might have argued otherwise.⁸¹ As Neuschel has more recently warned, however, while the warrior may have evolved into the gentleman, historians should not recognize him too quickly, a position that the current work supports.⁸² Dewald and Asch have both set out to prove that the nobility of Europe were very good at adapting, usually as a reinvention from within rather than from outside pressures.⁸³

For instance, although the king expected Monluc's hospitality to be rustic at best, consisting of warm wine and foods spiced heavily with garlic and onions, the duke of Guise confirmed that instead the meat was flavorful, the wine was cool, the meal was served on white linens, and the drinking vessels were made of silver. Monluc believed in keeping a good table since men of "good blood and breeding" would follow (Monluc, bk. IV). While Elias has noted that the fork was one of the tools of the courtier, having been imported from Italy during the reign of Henry III, it did not mean that they were the only ones who used it.⁸⁴ Monluc's complaint

was that it was the only iron that courtiers ever handled (Monluc, bk. VI). Although Monluc's free and open heart prevented him from being a courtier, he mentions that during a siege he donned a pair of feather-covered "sexy breeches" and then paraded around in public in order to bring levity to an otherwise grim situation (Monluc, bk. III). He knew what the current fashions were, and although his attempts at playing the courtier were long behind him he still owned some of their stylings. Here, Monluc was taking on the affectations of the courtier, demonstrating that the knight was very aware of how he was supposed to look at court, even if he usually chose not to look that way.

Knights were willing to adopt the outward appearance of their more elegant rivals so long as such trappings did not hinder the forthrightness so integral to knightly masculinity. While serving at the table of Francis I, then eighteen-year-old Vieilleville, a lifelong soldier who would rise to be marshal of France in 1562, made an error that earned him a public slap in the face from the Maistre. Demonstrating the restraint that Elias would have said a knight was incapable of, Vieilleville let this affront pass out of respect for those present. However, later in private the young man demanded an apology. When he did not receive one, Vieilleville took out his sword and ran the Maistre through, all with the king's commendation for acting according to the nobility of his race (Carloix I.I.II). This was not the only time Vieilleville drew steel on a fellow noble, having done so in 1563 with the governor of Rouen over a disagreement (Carloix V.IX.XII). Regardless, during his career he was named counselor to the king, governor of the three bishoprics, the first count of Durtal, and diplomat for all of France while helping to negotiate the famous Treaty of Cateau-Cambr sis. While restraint and moderation were expected at court, it was also considered proper for certain men to reciprocate an affront to honor with violence. That Vieilleville rose through the ranks under various kings demonstrates that such behavior was approved for men of the sword. Similarly, Monluc expressed pride for his short-and-to-the-point soldierly speech rather than the flattering and flowery dialogue of the courtier, as well as his ability to swear (Monluc, bk. IV). Thus by century's end, knights were more cultivated and might look more like the courtier in his extravagant dress but refused to adopt behavior and speech that might subvert their masculinity to another man. The fact that nearly all of the dukes and peers of the blood in France still had careers in the military into the seventeenth century shows that knightly masculinity, although more professional and dressed in fancy clothes, still wielded considerable power in society.⁸⁵ Unlike Ch taigneraye, the masculine construction of the knight adapted to his opponent's challenge rose up again and was able to emerge victorious.

OVERCORRECTION

Unfortunately for France, fighting is exactly what the knight did, to the extent that modern scholars call the third quarter of the sixteenth century the French "Golden Age" of dueling.⁸⁶ Duels, whether judicial or private, were "for the purpose of proving either the truth of a disputed question or the valor, courage, and honor of each combatant."⁸⁷ Ch taigneraye and Jarnac's fight in 1547 was the last formal judicial duel, that is, one occurring with the permission and supervision of a recognized authority.⁸⁸ The private duel, on the other hand, needed no authority but took place in a public setting, usually with several other men acting as seconds to witness and report on the outcome of the point of honor in question. The willingness to engage in violence against a worthy opponent coupled with the public setting meant that the duel could substitute for war as a proving ground for masculinity among the martially inclined.

Other historians have previously sought to explain the rise of the duel as a way for a class under duress to either differentiate its status from the bourgeoisie or to resist the increasing jurisdiction of the nobility of the robe—a way for men of average privilege to make felt their difference.⁸⁹ Carroll sees the duel as a way for young noble sons to prove themselves without having to rely on the expense of being a fully armed and armored knight, touching on merit as a means of social recognition and advancement.⁹⁰ Gender is the nexus of these explanations, encapsulating them all. Threatened by social and military change, men who pursued knightly masculinity had to find a way to prove themselves masculine since war was now so anonymous.

Thus it is noteworthy that the private duel's origin, which Carroll dates to the mid-1520s, was simultaneous with the rise of the courtier and the growing prominence of gunpowder, suggesting that the strains they placed on advancement and acknowledgment of knightly masculinity are related to the dueling craze.⁹¹ Furthermore, figures from these early years indicate that duelists were usually young men who had spent some time at war but were still in the lower ranks of the nobility.⁹² As such, these men were trying to stake out a place for

themselves in an ever shrinking field of masculine recognition. The increased prominence of the courtier and the restriction of access to the judicial duel after midcentury, where knights may once have been able to appeal as a means of redress, also factor prominently in the proliferation of the private duel. As part of their desire to return to the ways of the knight to restore order, writers like Montaigne after midcentury lamented the fact that instead of holding tournaments to maintain their arms, men now sought out glory in private duels over points of honor.⁹³ This was nothing short of murder in their minds, but dueling had become the fashion of the day for young noblemen trying to earn or protect their reputation, status, and masculinity. According to contemporary statistics, between 1588 and 1608, seven thousand to eight thousand noblemen are supposed to have been devoured by this “monster,” although that number is most certainly an exaggeration.⁹⁴ Still, that men like Vieilleville were willing to immediately resort to swords, and even forgo a formal declaration of intent in some cases, demonstrates the mentality that had taken hold in men of the sword by the second half of the sixteenth century. He is not the only member of the upper nobility to have grown into such a perspective either. In response to others making fun of him behind his back, Monluc claimed, “But had I been within a pike’s length I should have made some of them silent that spoke very loud” (Monluc, bk. VI). While Monluc can often be dismissed as a blowhard, the fact that he was willing to immediately resort to violence when members of the king’s court had a bit of fun at his expense demonstrates how protective of their masculinity knights now were.

Recasting their profession, supporting a specific kind of education, and embracing fashion and culture all had a price for noble warriors. Essentially, in order to balance the equation of gender, once knights added more to their feminine side they needed to add more to their masculine side as well, lest they appear effeminate like the hermaphroditic courtier. Unfortunately, because of increasing anonymity in war and a lack of recognized opportunity to test, and therefore prove, their manhood, the independently minded knight felt forced to seek out the most trivial of excuses to lay claim to his birthright of independence and violent recourse. If the only time these men could bend their gender was on the public battlefield, which was increasingly limited to them, then it was through private battle that they would mend their gender to make certain they were not mistaken for anything less than fully masculine men.

NOTES

1. See Raewyn Connell, *Masculinities* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1995), which asserts that the crises of masculinity in the long sixteenth century laid the foundation for modern masculinity.

2. Darrin Cox, *Aristocratic Masculinity in France (1450–1550): From Knight to Courtier* (Lewiston, NY: Edwin Mellen Press, 2012), 7. Portions of the argument presented here are drawn from this earlier work.

3. See J. Clements and Belinda Hertz, “Duel of the Century: The Judicial Combat of Jarnac and Châtigneraye—France, 1547,” 1999, www.thearma.org/essays/DOTC.htm, for a thorough description of these events, although they do rely on the untrustworthy Powell.

4. François Billacois, *The Duel: Its Rise and Fall in Early Modern France*, trans. Trista Selous (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1990), 54.

5. Vincent Carloix, *Memoires de la vie de Francois de Scepeaux, sire de Vieilleville et comte de Duretal, marechal de France; contenant plusieurs anecdotes des regnes de Francois I, Henry II, Francois II, & Charles IX*, 5 vols. (Paris: H. L. Guerin & L. F. Delatour, 1757), vol. 1, bk. II, ch. XII. Hereafter cited as Carloix volume.book.chapter.

6. Billacois, *The Duel*, 55.

7. Pauline M. Smith, *The Anti-Courtier Trend in Sixteenth-Century French Literature* (Geneva: Droz, 1966), 43.

8. *Ibid.*, 46–53.

9. Sydney Anglo, “The Courtier: The Renaissance and Changing Ideals,” in *The Courts of Europe: Politics, Patronage and Royalty, 1400–1800*, ed. A. G. Dickens (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1977), 38.

10. Jean de Bueil, *Le Jouvencal par Jean de Bueil*, ed. Camille Favre (Paris, 1887), vol. I, pt. I, ch. 5. Hereafter cited as de Bueil volume.part.chapter.

11. Michel de Montaigne, “Essays,” in *The Complete Works of Montaigne: Essays, Travel Journal, Letters*, trans. and ed. Donald M. Frame (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1958), bk. 1, ch. 26.

12. Aldo D. Scaglione, *Knights at Court: Courtliness, Chivalry, and Courtesy from Ottonian Germany to the Italian Renaissance* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1991), 230.

13. John David Nordhaus, “*Arma et Litterae*: The Education of the Noblesse in Sixteenth Century France” (PhD diss., Columbia University, 1974), 149; and Kathleen Wilson-Chevalier, “Feminizing the Warrior at Francis I’s Fontainebleau,” in *Masculinities in Sixteenth-Century France: Proceedings of the Eighth Cambridge French Renaissance Colloquium*, 5–7 July 2003, ed. Philip Ford and Paul White (Cambridge: Cambridge French Colloquia, 2006), 23–24, respectively.

14. Cited in J. H. Hexter, “The Education of the Aristocracy in the Renaissance,” *Journal of Modern History* 22 (1950): 2.

15. Emmanuel Le Roy Ladurie, *The Royal French State, 1460–1610*, trans. Juliet Vale (Cambridge: Blackwell, 1994), 81; and Scaglione, *Knights at Court*, 230, respectively.
16. Cecil H. Clough, “Francis I and the Courtiers of Castiglione’s Courtier,” *European Studies Review* 8 (1978): 46–47.
17. Anglo, “The Courtier,” 36.
18. Billacois, *The Duel*, 194.
19. C. A. J. Armstrong, “The Golden Age of Burgundy: Dukes That Outdid Kings,” in *The Courts of Europe: Politics, Patronage and Royalty, 1400–1800*, ed. A. G. Dickens (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1977), 60.
20. Donna Bohanan, *Crown and Nobility in Early Modern France* (New York: Palgrave, 2001), 10.
21. Christopher Stocker, “Public and Private Enterprise in the Administration of a Renaissance Monarchy: The First Sales of Office in the Parlement of Paris (1512–1524),” *Sixteenth Century Journal* 9.2 (1978): 8–18.
22. R. J. Knecht, “The Court of Francis I,” *European Studies Review* 8 (1978): 2–4.
23. Wilson-Chevalier, “Feminizing the Warrior at Francis I’s Fontainebleau,” 24.
24. See Arthur Tilley, “Humanism under Francis I,” *English Historical Review* 15.59 (1900), for a thorough description of the royal professorships funded by Francis.
25. Dominic Baker-Smith, “‘Inglorious Glory’: 1513 and the Humanist Attack on Chivalry,” in *Chivalry in the Renaissance*, ed. Sydney Anglo (Rochester, NY: Boydell Press, 1990), 137–44.
26. Desiderius Erasmus, “The Complaint of Peace,” in *The Praise of Folly and Other Writings*, trans. and ed. Robert M. Adams (New York: Norton, 1989), 110.
27. *Ibid.*, 108.
28. Paul Solon, “Popular Response to Standing Military Forces in Fifteenth-Century France,” *Studies in the Renaissance* 19 (1972): 78.
29. Davis Bitton, *The French Nobility in Crisis, 1560–1640* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1969), 28.
30. Geoffrey Parker, “The ‘Military Revolution,’ 1560–1660: A Myth?” *Journal of Modern History* 48.2 (June 1976): 196. More on this process can be found in Cox, *Aristocratic Masculinity*, 199–202.
31. Kristen Brooke Neuschel, *Word of Honor: Interpreting Noble Culture in Sixteenth-Century France* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1989), 77.
32. Blaise, seigneur de Monluc, *Commentaires de Messire Blaise de Monluc*, trans. Cotton Charles (London: Andrew Clark, 1674), bk. 1. Hereafter cited in the text as Monluc, book.
33. Solon, “Popular Response,” 91.
34. Janine Garrison, *A History of Sixteenth-Century France, 1483–1598: Renaissance, Reformation, and Rebellion*, trans. Richard Rex (New York: St. Martin’s Press, 1995), 153.
35. Arlette Jouanna, *Ordre social: Mythes et hiérarchies dans la France du XVI^e siècle* (Paris: Hachette, 1977), 153. Jouanna has also demonstrated that the nobility commonly lamented that their sacrifice was not suitably rewarded (148).
36. For more on courage and humiliation, see Stuart Carroll, *Blood and Violence in Early Modern France* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2006), 49. For more on the submission of will, see Cox, *Aristocratic Masculinity*, 263–65.
37. Anglo, “The Courtier,” 41, disagrees with this assessment. He claims that *franchise* and *sprezzatura* are akin to one another. Also, Maurice Keen “Chivalry,” 249, denotes *franchise* to mean simply “independent spirit,” but I feel this definition lacks the attached moral virtues of acting rightly implied in the term. I take the definition of *sprezzatura* not only from my own readings of Castiglione but also from Harry Berger Jr.’s definition in “Sprezzatura and the Absence of Grace,” in *The Book of the Courtier: The Singleton Translation*, ed. Daniel Javitch (New York: Norton, 2002), 297.
38. Castiglione, bk. II, ch. 8.
39. Richard Barber, *The Knight and Chivalry* (Rochester, NY: Boydell Press, 1995), 382.
40. Nicolas Le Roux, *La faveur du roi: Mignons et courtisans au temps des derniers Valois* (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 2001), 36.
41. Cited in J. H. M. Salmon, *Society in Crisis: France in the Sixteenth Century* (New York: St. Martin’s Press, 1975), 96.
42. Donald Stone, *France in the Sixteenth Century: A Medieval Society Transformed* (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1969), 123.
43. R. J. Knecht, *Renaissance Warrior and Patron: The Reign of Francis I* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1994), 15, 69.
44. Vern L. Bullough, “Cross Dressing and Gender Role Change in the Middle Ages,” in *Handbook of Medieval Sexuality*, ed. Vern J. Bullough and James A. Brundage (New York: Garland, 1996), 225.
45. Ad Putter, “Transvestite Knights in Medieval Life and Literature,” in *Becoming Male in the Middle Ages*, ed. Jeffrey Jerome Cohen and Bonnie Wheeler (New York: Garland, 1997), 283.
46. Katherine B. Crawford, “Love, Sodomy, and Scandal: Controlling the Sexual Reputation of Henry III,” *Journal of the History of Sexuality* 12.4 (October 2003): 529.
47. *Ibid.*, 527–29.
48. James B. Wood, *The King’s Army: Warfare, Soldiers and Society during the French Wars of Religion, 1562–1576* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), 3–4.
49. Crawford, “Love, Sodomy, and Scandal,” 518.
50. *Ibid.*, 525.
51. Donald Stone Jr., “The Sexual Outlaw in France, 1605,” *Journal of the History of Sexuality* 2.4 (April 1992): 606.
52. Alan Bray, “Homosexuality and the Signs of Male Friendship in Elizabethan England,” in *Queering the Renaissance*, ed. Jonathan Goldberg (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1994), 50.

53. Smith, *The Anti-Courtier Trend*, 219, 124.
54. Floyd Gray, *Gender, Rhetoric, and Print Culture in French Renaissance Writing* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2000), 135.
55. Carroll, *Blood and Violence*, 89.
56. Goran Stanivukovic, "'The blushing shame of souldiers': The Eroticism of Heroic Masculinity in John Fletcher's *Bonduca*," in *The Image of Manhood in Early Modern Literature: Viewing the Male*, ed. Andrew P. Williams (Westport, CT: Greenwood Press, 1999), 41.
57. For an overview of the revisionist work that has sought to renew debate over Henry III's contributions to French society, see Robert Sauzet and Jacqueline Boucher, eds., *Henry III et son temps: Actes du Colloque international du Centre de la Renaissance de Tours, octobre 1989* (Paris: J. Vrin, 1992).
58. Joseph Cady, "The 'Masculine Love' of the 'Princes of Sodom,' 'Practicing the Art of Ganymede' at Henri III's Court: The Homosexuality of Henri III and His *Mignons* in Pierre de L'Estoile's *Mémoires-Journaux*," in *Desire and Discipline: Sex and Sexuality in the Premodern West*, ed. Jacqueline Murray and Konrad Eisenbichler (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1996), 123.
59. Stone, "The Sexual Outlaw," 598.
60. *Ibid.*, 597–98.
61. John O'Brien, "Betwixt and Between: Hermaphroditism and Masculinity," in Ford and White, *Masculinities in Sixteenth-Century France*, 133.
62. Gray, *Gender, Rhetoric*, 136.
63. Smith, *The Anti-Courtier Trend*, 61.
64. Stone, "The Sexual Outlaw," 605.
65. O'Brien, "Betwixt and Between," 135.
66. *Ibid.*, 137.
67. Hexter, "The Education," 1–2.
68. *Ibid.*, 3.
69. Nordhaus, "*Arma et Litterae*," 107.
70. Wilson-Chevalier, "Feminizing the Warrior," 25.
71. J. R. Hale, "Sixteenth-Century Explanations of War and Violence," *Past and Present* 51 (May 1971): 4.
72. Yuval Noah Harari, *Renaissance Military Memoirs: War, History, and Identity, 1450–1600* (Woodbridge: Boydell and Brewer, 2004), 4n.
73. D. J. B. Trim, *The Chivalric Ethos and the Development of Military Professionalism*, ed. D. J. B. Trim (Boston: Brill, 2003), 16.
74. Raimond de Beccarie de Pavie, baron de Fourquevaux, *Instructions for the Warres*, trans. Paule Ive (London: Thomas Orwin, 1589), bk. II, ch. 1.
75. Bohanan, *Crown and Nobility*, 11.
76. Du Bellay, vol. 1, prologue.
77. Nordhaus, "*Arma et Litterae*," 178.
78. *Ibid.*, 169.
79. *Ibid.*, 198–99.
80. Kate Van Orden, *Music, Discipline, and Arms in Early Modern France* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2005), 92.
81. Norbert Elias, *The Civilizing Process*, 1st American ed., Mole Editions (New York: Urizen Books, 1978).
82. Neuschel, *Word of Honor*, 205.
83. Jonathan Dewald, *The European Nobility, 1400–1800: New Approaches to European History* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), 3; and Ronald G. Asch, *Nobilities in Transition, 1550–1700: Courtiers and Rebels in Britain and Europe* (London: Arnold, 2003), 2.
84. Elias, *The Civilizing*, 69.
85. Mark Motley, *Becoming a French Aristocrat: The Education of the Court Nobility, 1580–1715* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1990), 10.
86. Billacois, *The Duel*, 81.
87. *Ibid.*, 5.
88. *Ibid.*, 18.
89. Hale, "Sixteenth-Century Explanations," 11; and Jouanna, *Orde sociale*, 163, respectively.
90. Carroll, *Blood and Violence*, 153.
91. *Ibid.*, 155.
92. *Ibid.*, 155.
93. Montaigne, bk. II, ch. XXVII; and Claude Fauchet, *Origines des dignitez et magistrats de France* (Paris, 1600), 8–9.
94. Richard Herr, "Honor versus Absolutism: Richelieu's Fight against Dueling," *Journal of Modern History* 27.3 (September 1955): 282; and Billacois, *The Duel*, 81, respectively.